

was the largest in the world. Part of its strength lay in its importance as a center of Christianity. The Byzantine church was the “Orthodox” church—in contrast to the various other forms of eastern Christianity that it considered heretical. The fact that the emperor was held to be God’s representative on Earth gave him great authority, but could also cause serious problems. Leo III, who ruled from 717 to 741, banned religious icons because he said they were being worshipped as idols. This became known as the Iconoclast controversy. The empire erupted in protest, and the icons were restored, to be “venerated” but not worshipped. Controversies of this kind added to the growing distance between the churches of the east and west.

Revival and collapse

The empire’s fortunes revived under the “Macedonian” emperors of the late 9th–early 11th centuries. It regained control of the Adriatic Sea, southern Italy, and all of Bulgaria. Cities grew and prospered, trade increased, and artistic and intellectual life flourished.

A shrinking empire

The gradual loss of Byzantine territory is evident through centuries of invasion from both the east and the west.

KEY

- Imperial frontier, c. 628
- Imperial frontier, c. 1030
- Imperial frontier, c. 1143
- Imperial frontier, 1328



However, after 1025 Byzantium fell into difficulties again. A string of weak rulers after Basil II (928–1025) allowed the once-formidable armed forces to fall apart. At the same time, the empire was faced with new, ambitious enemies, such as the Normans, who had taken southern Italy by 1071. But the greatest danger came from the Seljuk Turks in Asia Minor (present-day

Turkey). By 1080, most of Asia Minor had been lost and Byzantium’s fatal decline had begun. Desperate, Emperor Alexius sent embassies to Western Europe asking for help. The result was the series of military expeditions known as the Crusades (see pp.200–01). However, instead of helping their eastern brothers, the crusaders mostly pursued their own interests. Intended

to bring support to Constantinople, the so-called Fourth Crusade was the single most catastrophic event in Byzantine history. In 1204 a crusader army that was supposedly on its way to defend the Holy Land brutally sacked the city of Constantinople and dismantled the empire.



Bronze horses stolen from Constantinople
These horses once adorned the Hippodrome erected by Constantine in Constantinople. Looted by the Venetians in 1204, they were installed in St. Mark’s Basilica, Venice.



The Virgin Mary and Jesus are depicted in the highly stylized form of Byzantine icons.

Constantine I, the first Christian emperor and founder of Constantinople, offers the city itself to Mary and Jesus.

AFTER

In 1204 much of the Byzantine Empire was divided up between its crusader conquerors, but it survived and limped on until the fall of Constantinople to the Ottomans in 1453.

CONSEQUENCES OF THE SACKING

After the Fourth Crusade Constantinople was left underpopulated and in ruins. The city never really recovered. Chief beneficiary was the **Venetian Republic**, which took over much of the Byzantines’ trade as well as shipping fabulous quantities of loot back to Venice.

CONSTANTINOPLE BECOMES ISTANBUL

On May 29, 1453, the **Ottoman Turks** took Constantinople, renaming it **Istanbul**, and making it the capital of the Ottoman Empire **246–47**.

STOPPING THE OTTOMANS

Once Byzantium had fallen, the Ottomans completed their conquest of the Balkans with ease. Their progress was finally stopped by the Habsburg victory at Vienna in 1683.